

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

- **Iron Man Vol. 1 #120–129 #153–156** Tony Stark's first encounter with Justin Hammer and his battle with alcohol.
- **Iron Man Vol. 2 #162–200** Stark's long dark fall to the gutter at the hands of Obadiah Stane, and his gradual resurrection.
- **Iron Man Vol. 3 #27–30** The Iron Man armor becomes sentient and attacks Stark.

Although immensely strong-willed, at times the pressures on Tony Stark have proved overwhelming—twice he has succumbed to the lure of alcohol. Tony's first fall from grace was precipitated by a series of attacks from Super Villains hired by business rival Justin HAMMER. While fending these off, Iron Man was framed for the murder of a diplomat, and at the same time national security agency SHIELD were attempting to buy his company and so gain his military secrets. Gradually, with the support of his friends, Tony overcame these threats and defeated his addiction.

This episode was nothing compared to Tony's second dance with drink. As a result of the emotional manipulations of his competitor Obadiah STANE, Tony became a homeless vagrant. His epiphany came when he was forced to deliver the child of a homeless woman, who died soon after. After waking up in hospital, he began to rebuild his

Battling armored humans is now commonplace for Iron Man.



In the House of M universe, Tony Stark is a competitor in Sapien Death Match, a televised gladiatorial contest. There he competes against other armored humans.

OLD FLAMES

Wealthy, charming, handsome—over the years, countless women have been drawn to Tony Stark, and many hearts have been broken, including his own. Time and again, his dual identity and multiple responsibilities have sabotaged any hope at a settled, long-term romance.

JANICE CORD
Daughter of Stark rival Drexel Cord.

BETHANY CABE
Tony's lover until her husband returned.

SUNSET BAIN
Seduced Tony and stole his secrets.

VIRGINIA POTTS
One of Tony's most loyal confidantes.

NATASHA ROMANOVA
Sometime adversary and former fiancée.



Like his father before him, Tony Stark was cursed by the demon drink. With Iron Man labeled a murderer and his company under siege, Tony was driven to the bottle.

life, creating a new business empire—Stark Enterprises—and defeating Stane in combat.

AN ENEMY OF AMERICA

Although a long-term member of the Avengers, Tony's decisions have brought him into direct conflict with his teammates, as well as with the US government. When Justin Hammer stole

Stark technology and distributed it to criminals across the world, Tony began a quest to find each item of missing technology. His efforts to track down the US military's Stark-derived Guardians suits resulted in Iron Man being branded an outlaw by the US government. This action also antagonized CAPTAIN AMERICA.

A HEAVY BURDEN

During the Civil War (see pp. 84–5), Tony led the Super Heroes who complied with the Superhuman Registration Act and worked with SHIELD. When the conflict ended, he was named the new director of SHIELD and used his new power to set up the Fifty State Initiative (see pp. 118–9).

Unfortunately, because of his membership in the ILLUMINATI, Tony became the target of the Hulk's wrath during World War Hulk (see

pp. 152–5). This scandal was the beginning of the end for him. When the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326–7) of the SKRULL Empire caught Tony off guard, the public backlash forced his removal as director of SHIELD. The man who took his place—Norman Osborn (GREEN GOBLIN)—ordered his capture. Tony ran, making himself as much an outlaw as the heroes he'd once sought to capture for SHIELD. **AD, MF**



Although sometimes at odds with his fellow Avengers, Tony Stark remains one of the team's most constant members. While his money keeps the team afloat, it is as Iron Man that he really leaves his mark.